

NOTE ON INTONATION PATTERN: RISE AND FALL

For: SS1 English Language

1. What is Intonation?

Intonation is the way our voice rises ↑ or falls ↓ when we speak. It is the “music” or “tune” of English. It helps listeners know if you are asking a question, making a statement, giving a command, or showing surprise.

If you use the wrong intonation, people may misunderstand you even when your words are correct.

2. The Two Basic Intonation Patterns

A. Falling Intonation ↓

Your voice starts high and ***goes down*** at the end of the sentence. It shows that you are sure, finished speaking, or not expecting a “yes/no” answer.

We use falling intonation for:

Use	**Examples**
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Statements	I live in Abuja↓. School will resume on Monday↓.
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WH-Questions	What is your name↓? Where do you live↓? Why are you late↓?
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Commands	Stand up↓. Open your books↓. Stop talking↓.
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Exclamations	What a lovely day↓! How clever you are↓!
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B. Rising Intonation ↑

Your voice starts low and ***goes up*** at the end of the sentence. It shows a question, doubt, or that you have not finished listing items.

We use rising intonation for:

Use	**Examples**
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Yes/No Questions	Are you a student↑? Did you eat↑? Can she swim↑?
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Requests	Please help me↑? May I go out↑? Could you repeat that↑?
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Lists	I need pen↑, book↑, bag↑, and ruler↓. *Note: Rise on each item, fall on the last*
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****Doubt/Uncertainty**** You passed the exam↑? He is your brother↑?

3. Key Differences to Remember

1. *WH-questions ↓* vs *Yes/No questions ↑*

- Where are you going↓? _I want information_
- Are you going home↑? _I want yes or no_

2. *Statements ↓* vs *Questions with same words ↑*

- You are coming↓. _I am telling you_
- You are coming↑? _I am not sure, I'm asking_

4. Quick Practice

Say these aloud and use your hand to show ↑ or ↓:

1. Close the door↓.
2. Can you close the door↑?
3. Who closed the door↓?
4. We bought yam↑, rice↑, and beans↓.

5. Why It Matters

Correct intonation makes your English sound natural and polite. Wrong intonation can make a question sound rude, or a statement sound like you are not sure.

***Remember*:** ↓ = Final, Sure, Information. ↑ = Not final, Asking, Doubt.